E.C.Balázs

Curator and filmmaker · Founding Curator, The People's Museum for Prince

In 2016, after Prince died, I travelled to Minneapolis to grieve and found I was far from alone. At the Paisley Park fence and across the city, I met people from everywhere who carried a story about what his music had done to their lives. As a curator, I understood those stories as a collection in their own right, one no museum was gathering.

That became The People's Museum for Prince, and the question at the centre of my practice: what does an artist's museum look like when it is built with the people the art has reached? I think of it as a counter-museum, though not in opposition to anything. It sits beside the official story and asks who else holds that history. It carries grief and joy together, and it treats the people who love an artist as historians of that artist too.

THE PEOPLE'S MUSEUM FOR PRINCE

The museum is free and nomadic, and independent of the Prince estate. It gathers art, stories, letters, poems, music, performance and films through open calls. Each contribution is shown with care and credited to the person who made it. Professional artists hang beside people who have never exhibited before. Over ten years it has become a biographical portrait of Prince made by the people his work touched.

- **2018** · first season, Solar Arts Building, Minneapolis, with more than 3,000 visitors.
- **2026** · tenth-anniversary season, 7–27 June, at Roberts Gallery, The Capri and ColorWheel Gallery, with 76 contributors from nine countries.
- **The Living Archive** · every contribution, kept online year-round at archive.peoplesmuseumforprince.org
- **In the press** · The Guardian, NHK World, the Minnesota Star Tribune, KARE 11 and ABC Radio Melbourne.
- *Dearly Beloved* · my short documentary (2026) about a nine-year pilgrimage through Prince's Minnesota homes, premiered at the Atlanta Documentary Film Festival; Official Selection at the 45th Minneapolis St. Paul International Film Festival and the Melbourne Documentary Film Festival.
- **In print** · a chapter with historian Kristen Zschomler in *Blackstar Rising & the Purple Reign* (Duke University Press, 2026). In progress: books on The People's Museum for Prince and *The Houses of Prince*, the latter with Kristen Zschomler.

WORKING TOGETHER

I believe what the People's Museum learned can travel. Any artist whose work has changed lives leaves this second archive, held by the people who love the work. Often it surfaces around an anniversary, at a house or birthplace, or wherever visitors already arrive carrying something to tell.

I welcome conversations with artists' estates, house and birthplace museums, and foundations that feel this about their own audiences. Depending on the place, that might mean guest-curating a season; shaping an open call or archive that your own team carries forward; or making short films with the people whose lives the work touched. I'd rather begin with a conversation, and a visit if possible, than with a proposal.

ABOUT

- **PhD, Curatorial and Museum Studies**, University of Melbourne (2019). Dissertation: *A new curatorial model for an artist's museum*.
- **Twenty years in arts leadership and gallery direction** · Columbia University School of the Arts, LASALLE College of the Arts Singapore, Purchase College SUNY, George Mason University, and the National Art School Sydney (Interim Head of Studies, 2024–25).
- **Filmmaker by training** · Victorian College of the Arts; films screened at the Pompidou Centre and on SBS Television.

ecbalazs.com · peoplesmuseumforprince.org emma@ecbalazs.com